

How To Group Work



The concept of the Leuphana semester is a particular challenge for some students. You don't always have the luck of the draw and agreeing on a topic within the group can mean having to make compromises when choosing a focus. And why exactly does it feel like every discipline has its own ideas on how to cite?

If you like, the Leuphana semester is the first big test for group work during your studies. However, this also means that every frustrating experience or lesson in the first semester can turn out to be a real blessing for your future academic career. What's more, at some point in your professional life you will usually have to work in a team and be able to coordinate your work. It pays to practise early!

The idea is this: The whole is greater than the sum of its parts and together we can achieve more than each of us can on our own. Every group member plays their part. We focus on synergy effects: By exchanging ideas with each other, new ideas emerge and the team achieves a higher quality of work than would be foreseeable by simply adding up the individual contributions. What may sound trivial is actually hard work - only then can the group reach its full potential. Two of the biggest challenges: Not all members display the same motivation and arguments arise. Or the team spends more time on coordination and organization than on content-related work.

Well-known but unpopular motivational hurdles:

1. **Social loafing:** If group members have the feeling that their individual contribution to the group product is not identifiable, they make less effort. This effect is particularly evident in simple additive tasks. The members lack recognition for their performance.
2. **Free-riding:** If group members believe their contribution to group performance is meaningless or has no influence, they reduce their effort.
3. If someone in the group believes that other group members are being lazy or free-riding, they will make less of an effort themselves. They want to avoid being taken advantage of.

The principle behind this loss of motivation is diffusion of responsibility! The more group members, the less responsible each person feels for the success of the group work. This is because the responsibility is spread across all shoulders.

Sometimes it is supposedly small hurdles that set such a process in motion, e.g. difficulties in finding a common deadline. Dividing up the work chapter by chapter can turn out to be a lazy compromise. Not only does this make it much more difficult to produce a piece of work "from a single source"; it is also not uncommon for the main work to be left to individual people. The project is still graded for the entire group - after all, it was **group work**.

But of course it doesn't have to end like this. With a few little tricks, working on a joint project can become a productive pleasure. So here are some tips to make group work constructive, enjoyable and even a bit of fun:

1. Coordination

A certain degree of organization is also required in advance and continuously during the process in order to keep the organizational effort to a minimum. The group work can either be coordinated by a single person or the group can establish a corresponding process. Either way, the group should agree on a procedure at an early stage. It is important to note that it doesn't matter whether the group does it together, whether one person is appointed or whether they emerge during the first meetings (and are then appointed): Coordination does not mean "being the boss"! Rather, in this position you make sure, for example, that everyone has their say and is not overrun, or that the meetings remain productive and you don't get lost in the details. It's worth looking back on the past few weeks at regular intervals and thinking together about what worked well and what could work even better.

2. Clear distribution of tasks

The secret of a good division of labor lies less in defining clearly delineated areas of work as quickly as possible so that there is as little coordination as possible. Rather, it is about clear

Responsibilities. Whoever is responsible for the presentation does not necessarily create it alone. He or she may then be responsible for defining in good time when he or she needs what type and form of input from the other group members. But it remains the product of the group. It should be clear to everyone at all times which tasks a particular work package contains - and which do not. A regular exchange helps to distribute the workload fairly. In addition, the group members should be able to choose their own part of the task (the classic: who will give the presentation? Here too, volunteers first) - if no one can be found for a task, it must either go without or everyone takes on part of this unwelcome package. Each member of the group has different strengths, weaknesses and preferences. This can result in different roles within the team. Adapting the tasks to the strengths improves the motivation of each member and the success of the work will increase.

3. Planning is everything!

Common rules that the group agrees on at the beginning can save a lot of trouble afterwards. This can include a discussion about individual expectations or an agreement on when and how often you would like to meet to work together (as required or on fixed days?), how these meetings should take place (is there a moderator, a fixed schedule, time management?) or how you would like to communicate with each other (channels, availability, rules for respectful interaction).

In the vast majority of cases, major misunderstandings can be avoided from the outset. But sometimes `n o t h i n g` helps... Group members are not available, get in the way or are unreliable? Certain basic requirements for cooperative work must be met! If this is not the case, the most sensible thing to do is to address the problems concretely and openly with all those concerned. If that doesn't help either, seek a dialog with the teachers responsible and find a solution together - even if it means that you can no longer continue working in this constellation.

In this (hopefully rare) case, take a look at the following [article](#). You are not  alone!

Probably the best thing about the group work concept? Everyone can use their skills in a targeted way to lead the group to the desired result. If methods are used skilfully, communication between the members is good and you can learn from each other, then you will realize how much you can gain from group work at university. It promotes your social skills as well as your professional competence. And sometimes you make friends for life during the Leuphana semester.